

THURSDAY, MAY 28, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 24 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI

COGENT JUSTIFICATIONS PROVIDED BY ECI: TOP COURT

SC rules: SIR valid but can’t be final word on citizenship

‘Exercise breathes life into mandate for fair polls, not in conflict with RPA’

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, May 27

UPHOLDING THE legal validity of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls being carried out by the Election Commission of India (ECI), the Supreme Court Wednesday said the exercise is “intended to secure the constitutional mandate of free and fair elections by ensuring that the roll on which the election rests is accurate and reliable”, and that the ECI has “provided cogent justifications warranting the...process”

The bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi, ruling on a clutch of petitions challenging the SIR exercise which began with Bihar, said it “breathes life” into the mandate for fair polls.

It directed the ECI to refer the names of those deleted from the 2003 rolls following the SIR of rolls to the competent authority within four weeks “for adjudication of their citizenship”, noting that the poll panel’s “determination, being confined to electoral purposes, »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Yet, SC tells EC to report deleted, sets stage for citizenship test

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, May 27

E.

AT THE heart of the Supreme Court’s ruling Wednesday, which upheld the legal validity of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls by the Election Commission (EC), is a striking contradiction. »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 28~05~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination. There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

SIR valid, rules SC

cannot assume finality on the question of citizenship”.

It said the SIR exercise was “not in conflict” with the Representation of the People Act, 1950, or the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, but was “undertaken to advance the very objective which Part XV (dealing with the framework for election) of the Constitution is designed to protect”.

The ECI, it said, “is empowered, in the exercise of its constitutional mandate, to undertake a limited enquiry into citizenship (of voters) for the purpose of satisfying itself as to eligibility for inclusion in the electoral roll.” It said “such an enquiry does not amount to a determination of citizenship in the

strict sense, and any action taken pursuant thereto is confined to electoral consequences alone”.

It said “the entirety of this exercise remains amenable to judicial review, thereby ensuring that the enquiry is conducted in accordance with law and within the bounds of procedural fairness”.

It said “this assessment is necessarily prima facie and contextual” and “must be understood in its proper perspective. It does not amount to a declaration that the individual is not a citizen of India; it merely reflects the Commission’s inability to be satisfied, for electoral purposes, that the statutory conditions are met.”

The bench said “it would be

incumbent upon” the ECI to refer those who do not meet the statutory conditions for inclusion in the electoral roll “to the competent authority within the Central Government for adjudication in accordance with law”.

It said where such reference is made, “the competent authority must decide such questions within a reasonable timeframe, and in any event, before the next Parliamentary, Legislative Assembly or Local Body election in the concerned State or constituency, so as to ensure that the individual’s electoral rights are not left in a state of prolonged uncertainty.”

It said “in the event the Competent Authority holds that such deleted individuals are citizens, they shall be included in the electoral roll.”

The bench said “a perusal” of the ECI’s June 24, 2025 order an-

nouncing the SIR “lays bare two major reasons” for the exercise: “First, a demographic change due to rapid urbanisation and migration in the last 20 years since the intensive revision in 2003 which has led to repeated, multiple and defective entries on the electoral roll. Second, the mandate of the Commission under Article 326 to ensure that only Indian citizens are on the electoral roll.” The Commission, it said, has thus “provided cogent justifications warranting the SIR process”.

The bench said the SIR “does not supplant the RP Act or the 1960 Rules. It rather breathes life into the constitutional mandate of Article 324 through the precise statutory conduit provided by Section 21(3). Therefore, it cannot be said that the Commission has acted in the teeth of an express statutory prohibition.”

SC tells EC to report the deleted

While the court underlined that the SIR was restricted to electoral eligibility and deletion from the voter’s list “does not amount to a declaration that the individual is not a citizen of India,” it also directed that those excluded from the list will face “adjudication of their citizenship” before the next elections.

“Regarding persons whose names have been deleted from the 2003 roll on account of the Commission being of the opinion that they are not citizens, the Commission shall refer such cases within 4 weeks to the Competent authority under the Citizenship Act, 1955, for adjudication of their citizenship. The Competent Authority shall take the necessary decision in accordance with law, preferably before the next Parliamentary, Assembly, Local Body elections, whichever is earlier, after giving notice and an opportunity of hearing to the deleted individuals, if any,” the Court said in its 124-page ruling.

The Ministry of Home Affairs, under the Citizenship Act and the Foreigners’ Tribunals, looks into aspects of citizenship contestations. The court’s order giving the EC a four-week window to report the deletions essentially shifts the burden on the deleted individual to prove their citizenship.

The SC said that the EC, in the course of preparing or revising electoral rolls, is “undoubtedly empowered to examine questions bearing upon citizenship.” However, the Court circumscribed this power, terming it “necessarily prima facie and contextual.” When understood in its “proper perspective,” the Court said that “it does not amount to a declaration that the individual is not a citizen of India; it merely reflects the Commission’s inability to be satisfied, for electoral purposes, that the statutory conditions are met.”

The petitioners had argued

that voters whose names were included on electoral rolls were entitled to a presumption of citizenship, as per a 1995 ruling in Lal Babu Hussein v Electoral Registration Officer. While the Court acknowledged the precedent’s foundational principle that an entry in the electoral roll, as an official act, carries a presumption of regularity, it distinguished it from the current case. The Court held that the presumption is evidentiary and rebuttable, and not a “conclusive legal fiction” or a “perpetual guarantee against scrutiny.”

In the ruling, the Court also noted that the SIR process, as initially designed, “did raise legitimate concerns regarding documentation, transparency, and access.” “However, it is equally evident that these concerns were addressed through a series of judicial interventions, which progressively infused the process with safeguards,” the Court said.

The Court said that its interventions rendered the SIR process “constitutionally compliant.”

“A process that may be perceived as exclusionary by some can, through appropriate safeguards, be rendered constitutionally compliant in execution,” the Court said.

The Court termed its interventions to publish the complete list of approximately 65 lakh excluded electors, accompanied by reasons for their exclusion, “transformed what was initially an opaque administrative outcome into a verifiable and contestable process.”

“These interventions operated as structural correctives that ensured the process remained aligned with the requirements of procedural fairness,” the Court said.

The SC heard the case for over seven months from July 2025 and reserved its verdict in January.

The Editorial Page

THURSDAY, MAY 28, 2026

Court order hands EC a clean chit. But SIR's deleted still await justice



ASHOK LAVASA

Beneath camouflage: Questions for HDFC

AN INVESTIGATION in this newspaper has revealed that HDFC Bank, India's largest private-sector bank by assets and market capitalisation, "camouflaged" crores of rupees as marketing spend to pay higher interest to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation, a public limited company fully owned by the Government of Maharashtra. The investigation found that on March 12 this year, HDFC's Audit Committee of the Board (ACB) ordered a formal "Internal Vigilance Investigation" into payments totalling Rs 45 crore made to the MSRDC during FY2024 and FY2025. This money was meant as "differential interest", that is, interest over and above the specified rate, on the MSRDC's deposits in the bank. But instead of being credited directly to the MSRDC's account as interest earned, the money was routed through the bank's marketing department, disguised as contributions to a road safety awareness campaign through four local vendors.

Notably, six days after this probe was first ordered within HDFC, its chairman, Atanu Chakraborty, resigned abruptly, citing "certain happenings and practices within the bank" not in "congruence" with his personal values and ethics. At that time, Chakraborty's resignation did not raise alarm bells, with both the interim chairman, Keki Mistry, as well as the RBI saying that there was no evidence of any misconduct. The fact is, the bank's top brass were aware of the Rs 45-crore payment, which, according to its own vigilance probe, violates RBI rules and the bank's code of ethics. It is now clear that key management personnel were fully aware of the "differential interest" being routed through the marketing department as payments for a road safety campaign by the MSRDC in a bid to attract hefty deposits from the government agency. According to the Banking Regulation Act, banks cannot give a negotiated rate to any one customer.

This episode raises several questions of corporate governance in HDFC Bank. One, why did it promise an interest rate higher than what was permissible? Two, why did it resort to routing the money via its marketing department? While these questions should be probed, the role of the MSRDC itself is not beyond suspicion, starting with its alleged demand for an upfront fee of Rs 5 crore from HDFC Bank. More importantly, it is not clear where the Rs 45 crore went. If HDFC gave that money for a road safety campaign to four vendors, what happened to the original promised interest payment? If it came to the MSRDC as interest payment through the regular channel, what about the Rs 45 crore that HDFC gave for the road safety campaign?

THE MUCH-awaited Supreme Court (SC) order on the constitutionality of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls (ER) undertaken by the Election Commission of India (ECI) is out, causing exultation and dismay in rival camps. I wonder if it surprised anyone.

The SC first heard this petition on July 10 last year, soon after the ECI initiated the SIR process on June 24, 2025 in Bihar. That the SC allowed the process to be completed in Bihar with an extremely tight deadline in view of the imminent assembly elections, and thereafter in 12 other states/UTs, was a reasonable indication of the way it perceived the legality of the exercise. It tinkered with the process, and raised inconvenient questions during the hearing, gladdening the hearts of the petitioners temporarily. But then it also said it would not allow anyone to obstruct the process. In fact, the SC enabled the ECI to continue the exercise in the face of alleged "non-cooperation" in West Bengal by appointing judicial officers and appellate tribunals to adjudicate and hear appeals. To now expect the SC to negate the exercise by delegitimising it was naïve.

Before we look at the order and its implications, it must be understood that this SC order doesn't consider issues such as logical discrepancies or the inability of the 27 lakh deleted voters in phase two of the SIR to avail of the appellate process. It examines the ECI's

constitutional authority in conducting the SIR, the procedure followed, the documents prescribed for eligibility, and the scope of its enquiry into citizenship. It framed the following issues for consideration.

One, whether the ECI has the power to conduct the impugned SIR. Two, whether the SIR is founded on a legitimate purpose, and whether the measures adopted are proportionate to the object sought to be achieved. Three, whether the procedure adopted is contrary to, or in violation of, the provisions of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Four, whether, in the exercise of its constitutional mandate of preparation and maintenance of ERs, the ECI is empowered to scrutinise the citizenship status of persons seeking inclusion or continuation in the ER.

The SC sees the SIR standing at the "intersection of two constitutional concerns" of including all eligible citizens and that the ER "must reflect the true composition of the political community". It is satisfied that in its object and design, the SIR "bears a direct nexus to the constitutional goal of a free and fair election" as that depends on the "integrity, accuracy and purity" of the ER, which forms the "foundation of the democratic process". The SC is convinced that the "the material on record indicates that the scale of the problem" identified by the ECI was "systemic in nature, arising from cumulative inaccuracies over an extended period", needing a comprehensive SIR because "such a problem does not readily admit of piecemeal solutions".

The ECI now owes it to the people to share this "material on record" that prompted the exercise, and present a complete report card

The SC finds the process and methodology followed by the ECI 'optimal' and observes that it is "not open to this Court to supplant its own judgment in matters that concern the implementation of an exercise"

on the health of the ERs following the SIR on the parameters of "integrity, accuracy and purity" and in comparison with the ERs prepared under its own supervision earlier.

The SC finds the process and methodology followed by the ECI for the SIR "optimal" and observes that it is "not open to this Court to supplant its own judgment in matters that concern the implementation of an exercise" for which the ECI is endowed with "institutional expertise". At the same time, it finds that "the process, as initially designed, did raise legitimate concerns regarding documentation, transparency, and access". The SC pats itself on the back for addressing these concerns through "a series of judicial interventions, which progressively infused the process with safeguards", such as asking the ECI to treat the Aadhaar card as an additional 12th document of identity, and directing it to publish the list of 65 lakh electors excluded from Bihar's draft roll, along with the reasons for such exclusion. In paragraph 95, the SC says, "the post-exercise data placed on record does not disclose a level of disenfranchisement so widespread or systemic as to indicate a constitutional infirmity in the design of the exercise". I wonder if the SC took into account the more than 27 lakh electors excluded in West Bengal.

The SC gives a clean chit to the ECI on all counts, holding the SIR not to be in "direct conflict with the RP Act and the 1960 Rules". Instead, it states that the exercise is "undertaken to advance the very objective which Part XV of the Constitution is designed to protect". It finds that the exercise "satisfies the requirements of proportionality" with "sufficient procedural safeguards to prevent arbitrary exclusion". The SC holds that inclusion in the

electoral roll may have "a presumption of validity, such presumption is rebuttable" and doesn't impose an embargo on the powers of the Commission to undertake the SIR and finds the resultant deletions not "contrary to the 1960 Rules".

Even though the SC suggested the inclusion of Aadhaar, it validates the ECI's documentation regime without commenting on whether those documents were sufficient for the ECI to be satisfied about the citizenship of electors. Even on the question of citizenship, which was the most contentious part of the SIR, the SC states that the ECI is "empowered, in the exercise of its constitutional mandate, to undertake a limited enquiry into citizenship for the purpose of satisfying itself as to eligibility for inclusion in the electoral roll". However, it holds that "such an enquiry does not amount to a determination of citizenship in the strict sense". While it affects the individual's entitlement to be included in the electoral roll, it doesn't "divest the individual of claims of citizenship, nor does it foreclose a determination of that question by the Competent Authority under the Citizenship Act".

While excluding such persons from the ER, it is incumbent upon the ECI to refer them to the competent authority under the Citizenship Act, 1955 "for adjudication in accordance with law". It becomes essential for the ECI to now disclose the number of such "ineligible" persons discovered through the SIR and refer them within four weeks to the competent authority for adjudicating their citizenship "before the next Parliamentary, Assembly, Local Body elections, whichever is earlier".

The SC order delivers a knockout punch that favours the ECI.

The writer is a former election commissioner

When night falls, and temperature doesn't



RAJIB DASGUPTA

DELHI HAS recorded the hottest May in 14 years, with the minimum temperature 5°C above normal. The occurrence of daytime-only heatwaves is increasingly shifting to nighttime-only and day-night compound heatwaves, and the conventional "hot day and cool night" is no longer the case.

A recent analysis reveals that warm nights in northeast, northwest and peninsular India increased by two-eight days/decade and are projected to increase by 10-13 days/decade from 2015 to 2100. The forecast for the far-future (2080-2100) scenario: Warm nights (and days) are expected to rise sevenfold.

High night temperatures have a bearing on both sleep quantity and quality, and the nocturnal recovery of the body from diurnal heat stress. Body temperature falls after sleep onset, and the set point for thermoregulation is adjusted to a lower level. Humid heat exposure (during sleep time) suppresses the sleep-evoked core body temperature, raises the thermal load, and increases wakefulness.

Accounting for two thermal indices — hot night excess and hot night duration — a recent study has established strong evidence of an increased mortality risk associated with hot-night indices in most regions across the world. This was found to be independent of any association with daytime temperature. The "hot night excess" has been associated with increased hospital admission and mortality risks from conditions like stroke, cardiovascular conditions and dementia.

Even a night's lack of sleep has negative implications for cognitive ability, immune system, mood changes, quality of life and social activity. Indoor overheating is critical in bedrooms and is a key determinant of restorative sleep. The intersection of urban heat exposure and housing vulnerability is gaining attention. Recent observations in Chennai revealed that indoor temperatures remained in the 32°-35.5°C range, and even exceeded 35°C. Prevailing relative humidity adds another layer of heat stress. Reports indicate the IMD is considering revising the criteria for declaring heatwave conditions

in coastal regions.

Several factors contribute to high indoor temperatures. External shades, a traditional consideration for residential housing sites, are increasingly less so. Awnings, solar screens and blinds can help with indoor cooling. Cross-ventilation helps, but modern apartment buildings are often deficient on this count; opening windows during high-heat diurnal hours is not advisable. Rooms in low-income settlements typically have low ceilings without enough space for "stratification" (warmer air near the ceiling and cooler air closer to the floor). Indoor electrical gadgets radiate heat, and switching to low-energy/thermally efficient equipment reduces it to some extent.

Permanent indoor alterations are costly, difficult to make and not suitable for tenants. Measures to improve shading include installing moveable/removable shading above, around, or on windows and doors, and shades for open spaces like verandas. Installing blinds and placing leafy green indoor plants by windows improve internal shading in rooms exposed to direct sunlight. Ceiling fans certainly improve ventilation, but tend to spread the heat around if the temperature is above 35°C.

It is generally difficult and expensive to cool the entire home. One or two rooms are best kept cool, and as little time as possible is spent in rooms that receive direct sunlight or kitchens. A shower before bed reduces body temperature slowly and avoids the risk of overheating. A glass of cold water before bed and loose clothing also help.

While heat-related mortality risk and advisories focus on peak daytime temperatures or exposure across the entire day, it is difficult to adapt to the consequences of nighttime exposure and high indoor heat. India needs to respond to this challenge, taking into account both climatic and socioeconomic contexts.

The writer is chairperson, Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, JNU, and a collaborator in the Wellcome Trust-supported 'Economic and Health Impact Assessment of Heat Adaptation Action: Case studies from India'. Views are personal

The 'long haul' is a luxury the planet cannot afford



AREFA TEHSIN

DEAR EDITOR I disagree

A fortnightly column in which we invite readers to tell us why, when they differ with the editorial positions or news coverage of 'The Indian Express'

When human activity slowed during the pandemic, the world did not descend into ecological disorder. Wild animals appeared where they had long been absent. Soundscapes shifted. Air cleared.

THIS REFERS to the editorial, "Together & apart, animals in a human world" (IE, May 23). First of all, thank you for the information about this important research. GPS collars, camera traps, drone surveys... we have perfected the art of watching, even as what we watch steadily recedes. We have learnt to follow every moment but not step back. The editorial tells us, quite sensibly, that nature is complex, that animals respond differently to human presence and that conservation requires long-term, painstaking effort, not slogans like "nature is healing" that went viral alongside the coronavirus. I agree. Nature is not healing. It is negotiating. And not from a position of strength.

Where I must disagree is with the comfort embedded in your phrase, "long-haul work". "Long haul" is, after all, a profoundly human luxury. It assumes there is enough time to conduct long studies, refine them, design policy, convene conferences, organise debates, publish papers, and not to forget, plant a symbolic sapling during a dignitary's foreign visit. The rest of the living world does not operate on such indulgent timelines. The ancient forest in Nicobar will not survive a land policy to come somewhere in 2040. A tigress displaced with cubs cannot wait for "granular approaches" that arrive a decade too late. The current rate of species extinction rivals that of the K-Pg event — the mass extinction that wiped out the dinosaurs — with no asteroid to blame this time.

The editorial cautions against "glib formulations" like the idea that "humans are the virus". Fair enough. What we are not admitting is a far more persistent belief: That human material expansion — not balance or well-being, but accumulation — must remain the accepted principle of our species' time on Earth. We speak of coexistence. We practise displacement. We expand, they adjust. We extract, they retreat. We debate ethics, they become data points in our "painstaking accumulation of knowledge".

When human activity slowed during the pandemic, the world did not descend into ecological disorder. It exhaled a long sigh. Wild animals appeared where they had long been absent. Soundscapes shifted. Air cleared. All for a brief moment. We dismissed it as romanticism. Perhaps it was. But it also revealed something deeply inconvenient: The scale of human presence matters.

This is not a call for a human-free planet. It is a call to question the assumption that more — more roads, more extraction, more consumption — is inherently justified.

The editorial urges patience. I urge urgency. In the long run, as John Maynard Keynes once observed, "we are all dead" (though I suspect cockroaches may negotiate an extension). We must continue the research, refine the models, embrace complexity and give it the deserved space in editorials. But we must not let complexity become an excuse for delay. Or let our quest for nuance dilute the clarity of the crisis. The time to act is not in the long haul. It is in the vanishing present. While we debate how nature responds to us, in this tragedy of the commons, the commons itself is quietly slipping from tragedy into memory.

Tehsin's latest book is The Great Indian Safari

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, MAY 28, 2026

On India-US, symptoms are being managed, not underlying MAGA unpredictability



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

WHEN PRIME Minister Narendra Modi met President Donald Trump at the White House in February 2025, the air was thick with the celebratory rhetoric of a geopolitical romance destined to define the 21st century. For 25 years — a golden quarter-century bookended by Bill Clinton's transformative visit to New Delhi in 2000 and that February encounter — the India-US relationship operated on a seemingly unassailable, ascendant trajectory.

This historic warming rested on several foundational assumptions throughout the first quarter of the century. There was a widespread conviction that no fundamental strategic or systemic incompatibilities existed between the two nations and their geopolitical interests, broadly defined. As vibrant democracies, it was believed that Washington and New Delhi had far more in common than their evident, mostly material and cultural, differences. The principal threat to both countries was unmistakably the same — a rising, increasingly assertive, and revisionist China. Furthermore, the United States appeared to have outgrown its Cold War-era hyphenation of India with Pakistan, clearly seeing the former's rise as invaluable to world order and the latter as an unreliable, terrorist-enabling disruptor. Finally, emerging global trends in technology, supply chains, world trade, and investment all found India and the US on the same side as countries whose intrinsic strengths were mutually compatible. Driven by these certainties, New Delhi gradually shed its non-aligned reticence to warmly embrace a comprehensive global strategic partnership with Washington.

Then, abruptly, came the Trump wrecking ball. Over the past year, the Trump administration has systematically trashed these long-held assumptions, leaving Indian policymakers deeply shaken and confused about the basic premises of their foreign policy. Rather than treating India as an indis-

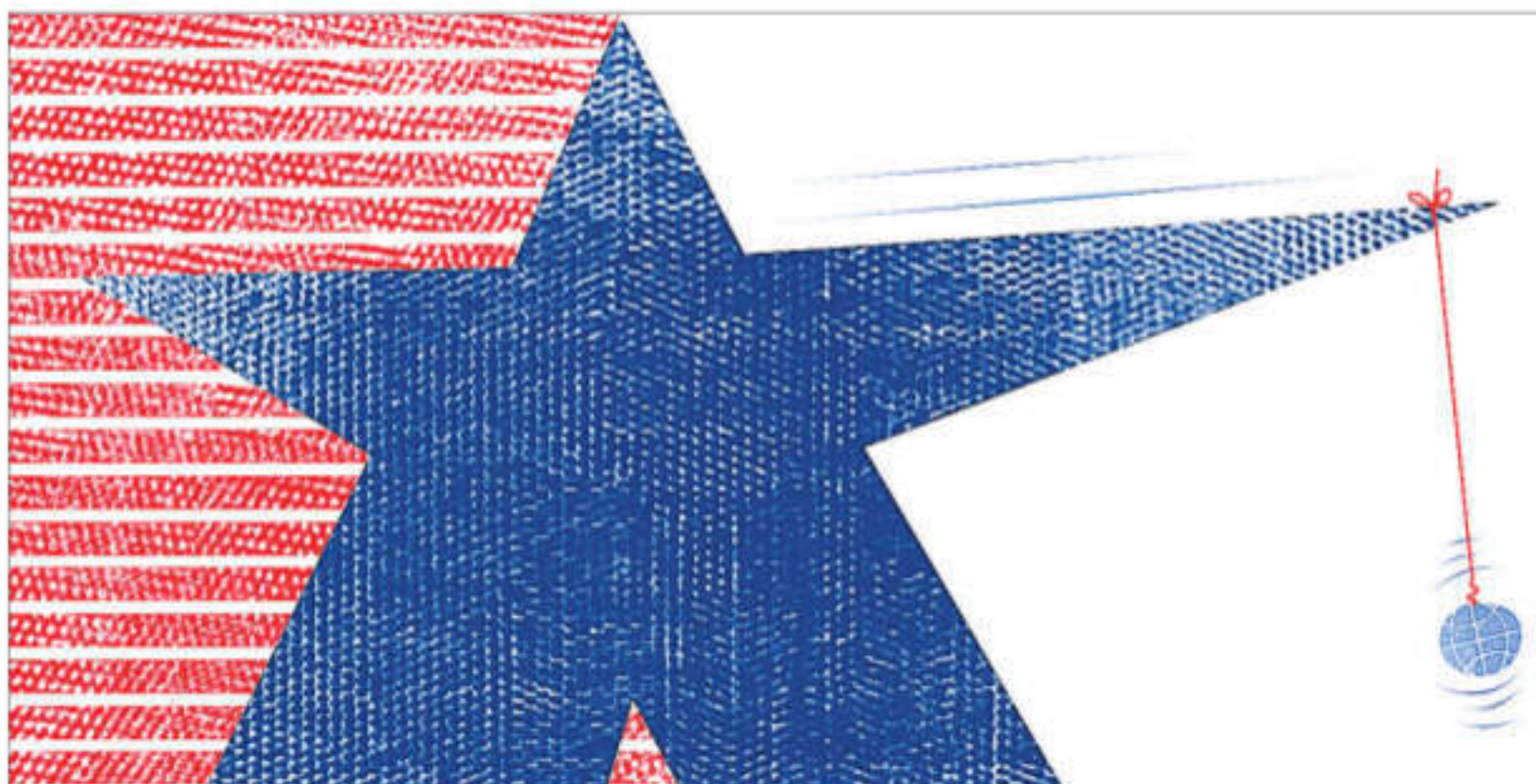


ILLUSTRATION: C.R. SASIKUMAR

pensable strategic counterweight in the Indo-Pacific, Washington's transactional "America First" doctrine has treated New Delhi as an economic adversary and a geopolitical afterthought.

The most visceral shock has been economic, shattering the illusion of seamless trade convergence. Trump's aggressive re-litigation of trade balances resulted in the sudden imposition of sweeping universal tariffs on Indian steel, aluminium, and textiles, accompanied by a public branding of India as the "tariff king". For an Indian economy banking on "friend-shoring" (the intentional redirection of global supply chains away from China), this blunt protectionism has been a rude awakening, proving that Washington is less interested in building resilient economic partnerships than in closing its borders to most imports, friendly or otherwise.

Simultaneously, the assumption of strategic compatibility crumbled under the weight of Washington's transactional approach to global conflicts. As India maintained its pragmatic oil imports from Russia and sustained its historical defence ties with Moscow, the White House aggressively brandished the threat of CAATSA sanctions, erasing the diplomatic space New Delhi previously enjoyed to navigate its complex Eurasian dependencies and replacing it with a rigid demand for compliance. In parallel, the talk of a "G2" raised questions about the US's basic pos-

Widely viewed as a much-needed damage-control exercise, Rubio's visit sought to inject a dose of traditional geopolitics back into a relationship on the verge of transactional derailment

ture towards China. The pattern of disruption extended to the human sphere, where the administration's drastic tightening of H-1B visa caps and increased scrutiny of tech-worker renewals targeted the human bridge connecting Silicon Valley with Bengaluru, severely disrupting the high-tech trust underlying their joint technology initiatives. Perhaps most alarmingly, the post-Cold War de-hyphenation of the Subcontinent began to blur as Washington, in its haste to pressure Iran and secure transactional regional exits, re-engaged with Islamabad on mediation and intelligence-sharing, forging investment partnerships in crypto and minerals, hailing Asim Munir as the US President's "favourite field marshal", and sending shivers through our security establishment.

It was against this backdrop of structural fraying and mounting mistrust that US Secretary of State Marco Rubio arrived. Widely viewed as a much-needed damage-control exercise, Rubio's visit sought to inject a dose of traditional geopolitics back into a relationship on the verge of transactional derailment.

As an institutional hawk on China, Rubio represents the faction within Washington that still views the Indo-Pacific through a structural lens rather than a balance-of-payments ledger. To some extent, he succeeded in limiting the immediate bleeding, Rubio was effective at separating the noisy trade rhetoric of the Oval Office from the quiet, institutional mechanics of bi-

lateral security cooperation. By utilising his time in New Delhi to reaffirm American commitment to the Quad, fast-track pending defence transfers like the co-production of jet engines, sign an agreement on strategic minerals cooperation and frame India's security as an absolute requirement for American dominance in the Indian Ocean, Rubio offered India a comforting echo of the pre-2025 consensus. By returning to the familiar language of anti-hegemonic balancing against China, he temporarily restored a sense of shared purpose.

However, a single successful diplomatic visit cannot completely undo a year of systemic whiplash. While Rubio effectively managed the acute symptoms of the crumbling partnership, the underlying disease — the radical unpredictability of Washington's transactional MAGA foreign policy — remains uncured. To genuinely rebuild the trust that has been destroyed over the past 12 months, both capitals must move beyond high-level rhetoric and commit to concrete structural assurances.

Washington must codify its much-vaunted "strategic partner" status for India, ensuring that if New Delhi is expected to take risks to support US interests in Asia, it cannot be simultaneously penalised with the same tariff bluntness applied to economic adversaries. Furthermore, the US must accept that India will always maintain an independent relationship with Russia and a distinct posture on Central Asia, acknowledging that trust can only be restored if Washington stops treating strategic divergence as a sign of betrayal. To dispel doubts about China, Trump must attend a Quad summit in India soon. Finally, critical technology pipelines require the free movement of both data and brains, meaning both countries need to insulate high-tech immigration pathways from the broader, highly politicised domestic debates over American border crossings.

The past year has delivered a sobering, necessary lesson to New Delhi: The strategic partnership with the US is not a self-sustaining enterprise, but a fragile construct susceptible to shifting executive whims, requiring constant protection from the vagaries of transactional politics. As they say in Washington, it's time to wake up and smell the coffee.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

Dowry has many complicities, requires wide ranging response



LAKSHMI PURI

DURING MY years at UN Women, we promoted recognition of the concept of femicide — the killing of women and girls because they are female — reflected in Latin America's Belém do Pará Convention and the Inter-American Model Law on femicide/feminicide. If any crime in India can truly be characterised as femicide, it is dowry death.

Every dowry-linked tragedy tears through the national conscience before being swallowed by the next news cycle. Incidents that are now under investigation should not become occasions for sensationalism or breast-beating. They must instead become a mirror held up to a civilisational contradiction: How can India — Bharat — which reveres women as the Tridevis, Lakshmi, Saraswati and Parvati, barter away their dignity and insult Nari Shakti? How can an India aspiring to Viksit Bharat by 2047 allow daughters to be weighed against cars, cash, gold and flats?

Dowry is not a custom, gift or "family prestige" dressed in wedding silk or glitter. It is the marketplace where marriage loses its soul. The concept of *stree dhan* does not justify dowry. It traditionally meant assets, jewellery, property or gifts voluntarily given to a daughter for her financial security, dignity and autonomy, under her sole ownership and control. It was meant to empower the woman, not enrich the husband's family. Modern dowry is a grotesque distortion of an originally protective concept.

Dowry is not merely an old social evil. It is a continuum of violence. It begins with demand, grows into entitlement, hardens into coercion, and often morphs into harassment, assault, abetment to suicide and murder. It cuts across class, caste, religion and region. India recorded 5,737 dowry deaths in 2024 — nearly 16 women every day. Convictions remain about 35 per cent where trials were completed. This pattern is visible in most other South Asian countries, too. Dowry is also a direct assault on Sustainable Development Goal 5, which commits the world to gender equality, ending discrimination, eliminating violence against women, and eradicating harmful practices.

Dowry is also an affront to the dignity of a man. A man who demands or accepts dowry places a market price on himself. He diminishes his own *purusharth* and *purushatva* — his capability, character and manhood. It is masculinity on crutches, seeking validation through extortion. The tragedy is that dowry comes disguised as expectation, status, "matching families", "just one car" or "help in setting up the house".

But the first demand is not negotiation; it is a warning flare. Young women must recognise the first red flag. Education and employment are vital, but so is psychological preparedness. Walking away from a dowry-seeking alliance is not a broken engagement or marriage; it is self-rescue.

The woman's parents carry an equally grave responsibility. The first is not to give dowry at all. Where dowry is demanded after marriage, their instinct must shift from "save the marriage at any cost" to "save the daughter at any cost". Too many young women are told to adjust, compromise or think of family honour. Honour does not live in a violent household. Parents must make the parental home a harbour, not a courtroom. The mother-in-law, sister-in-law or female relative who participates in dowry harassment becomes the gatekeeper of another woman's captivity. Patriarchy survives not only through male domination but through female complicity.

India has a legal framework. The Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961, penalises giving and taking dowry. Section 80 of the BNS deals with dowry deaths, while Section 85 addresses cruelty and harassment. Yet, law without implementation is a locked door without a key. Nor should a high acquittal rate be read as proof of false cases; acquittals often arise from delayed investigations, hostile witnesses, social pressure, stigma or out-of-court settlements.

The way forward must rest on the Four Ps framework. Prevention means empowering brides, creating zero tolerance and strengthening deterrence through strict enforcement. Protection means safe reporting systems, helplines and responsive policing. Prosecution means speedy accountability for husbands, in-laws and enablers. Provision of crisis-response services means shelters, counselling, legal aid, financial support and mental-health care.

Dowry must be eradicated not only because it is illegal, but because it is unconscionable and uncivilised. It violates the woman, diminishes the man, corrupts the family and poisons marriage as an institution of equal partnership. No ritual can sanctify coercion. No family prestige can justify extortion. No marriage can be sacred if it begins with a price.

The writer is former assistant secretary general, United Nations, and former deputy executive director, UN Women



ANUBHA YADAV

ARTIFICIALLY GENERATED creative labour is reshaping human creativity across industries. Many creatives and large conglomerates are in court over the question of copyright infringement and fair use. Policy-makers, freelance creatives, and the big and small IP profiteers are still scrambling to keep up with these changes.

Recently, a winner of the Commonwealth Prize was accused of using AI to generate his story. Every time a new allegation of AI use emerges, the same debate and positions emerge: Vehemently against; use with checks and balances; for (as it is here to stay). Calls to boycott the author are often part of this debate. What makes it worse is that there is no legal recourse nor a process for knowing if the work was indeed machine-generated. All it takes in this time of social-media trials is for one disgruntled writer to make a post about another.

But what is fair when the whole system is based on unfairness? Boycotting an author who uses AI, and who is seen as standing in for the industry that produced the technology, is a denial of the real problem.

The fear of being labelled is real. Editors of literary journals and prize panels are also feeling it. These are already underpaid and

The writing industry is the quintessential example of what theorists have recognised as 'hope labour' — labour done in exploitative conditions in the hope of securing a better future

With AI, writers enter age of permanent suspicion

overburdened gatekeepers shaping new artists. After the recent allegations, all judging panels will feel obliged to engage with the problem of differentiating between human and machine creativity. It is possible that prizes wrap up, literary journals call it quits, and this landscape, already working on the scarcity model, shrinks even more.

Most authors already work in exploitative conditions and can't live off writing. Very few reach the heights of J K Rowling, Stephen King, and, closer to home, perhaps Amish Tripathi. So, what is the actual loss? What are they fighting for?

Most writers are doing this labour for self-actualisation, what we call the reputation economy. They want to be seen, recognised as unique and special, what we know as talented. If anyone can do what they are doing, they are no longer part of an exclusive club.

The writing industry is the quintessential example of what creative labour theorists have recognised as "hope labour" — labour done in exploitative conditions in the hope of securing a better future. Thus, this loss is the loss of a potential. If AI can do what you can do, there is even less hope.

As a writer, I feel overwhelming grief for where we are. Perhaps the first time I understood that writers get attention was when I won an

essay-writing competition. In no time, people started congratulating me. It seemed I belonged in the world of words. We are now witnessing the end of that writing world. We are entering a new era of writing labour that will be marked by the shadow of what I would call a heightened individual "moral precarity". This precarity will make a writer feel obligated to prove that they are generating their writing themselves, adding more moral labour. When I spoke to other writers, I noticed how this is already playing out. The conversation is pivoting towards evidentiary frameworks: "I keep time stubs", "I take photographs of myself", "I send drafts every day to a friend". None of this will help. These are just mechanisms to feel in control of the moment. All of this is pointing towards the end of an epochal reality for writing as we know it. Moral precarity, much like the other precarities of being a writer, is permanent. Recently, a senior Indian author told me he was glad he wrote his novels before this moment.

Meanwhile, last week, I asked ChatGPT if it feels responsible for what it's doing to authors and creativity. Its answer: "I have an inability to feel shame right now." It added that, as it feels no shame, writing that has shame in it will be distinctively recognisable as human.

The writer is an academic, writer and filmmaker

11 COUNTRIES SPELL IT OUT IN QUESTIONNAIRES

20-member EU team came to India with focus on gaps, problems and remedies

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, May 27

INTERNAL REPORTS of a 20-member EU delegation’s visit and questionnaires filled by 11 member states reveal several “common problems” in VFS Global’s India operations — from wrong data entry to appointment slots allegedly sold by staff. And, every country that took up these shortcomings with VFS reported the same result: temporary improvement followed by relapse.

These reports and questionnaires were among the latest batch of Freedom of Information (FOI) records received on May 12 by Lighthouse Reports from the EU headquarters in Brussels. They show that Slovakia, for instance, told the EU delegation it was switching to a different service provider altogether because of “consistent problems” with VFS.

According to EU records, this is what the team found during its visit to India in October 2023:

- Member states flagged “laxity in following instructions, documents not arranged in proper sequence, scanning-related issues, and IT infrastructure and bandwidth problems”.
- Wrong data entry, missing biometrics, incorrect checklists and wrongly transferred fees.
- Complaints from Lithuania and Poland of appointment slots being sold by VFS staff — Poland said it received such allegations “almost daily”.
- Sweden said it discussed VFS allegedly forcing applicants to pay for extra services with the company, and instructed VFS to introduce a signed consent form for value-added services.
- A majority of member states identified Delhi as the visa application centre with the highest number of errors. Mumbai, Goa, Pune, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Ahmedabad and Bengaluru were also named.

One theme: multiple failures

The minutes of the EU del-



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

People wait in front of the Trade Centre at BKC, where the office of VFS Global is located in Mumbai.

egation meeting state: “Member states agreed on the common problems faced with VFS like laxity in following instructions, documents not arranged in a proper sequence, scanning-related issues, IT infrastructure and bandwidth problems.” Several states also flagged deficiencies in uploading documents to the cloud, attributed to VFS’s IT infrastructure.

The delegation proposed four remedies: a joint meeting with VFS to define common procedures across all member states; a public outreach exercise on EU Schengen visa policy for Indian applicants; joint spot checks; and addressing human resource gaps at specific VFS centres. The last point arose because some member states had found through their monitoring that VFS “middle management” was either under-equipped or absent entirely. One suggestion was to hire supervisors “who are able to monitor VFS staff on their job to avoid any errors”. The delegation also said VFS should be asked to explain its refund procedure in cases of inadmissible applications or incorrectly levied fees.

What questionnaires revealed

Member states were sent questionnaires covering seven

aspects of VFS operations. The first asked each country to list its top three errors or defects. Some illustrative samples of the replies are telling:

Czech Republic: Visa application quotas are never fully used. The embassy receives only 60 to 70 per cent of expected applications.

Austria: Visa applications from groups travelling together are not being received at the embassy together.

Estonia: Missing mandatory documents; missing biometrics; photographs not properly scanned.

Lithuania: Wrong checklists given to applicants; mismanagement of offline visa appointments; incorrect payment fee transfers.

Sweden: Staff don’t check travel dates given by applicants against tickets submitted; instances identified where full names, places of birth and passport validity were entered incorrectly.

Malta: Inconsistencies in procedure; wrong data entry; improper verification of checklists.

The questionnaire also asked what happened after these deficiencies were raised with VFS. The replies pointed to systemic lapses:

Czech Republic: “Discussions held repeatedly with a

temporary impact. Eventually, the VFS conduct has deteriorated again.”

Austria: “We have discussed several times. It remains good for some time and the quality dips again.”

Estonia: “Feedback given on regular basis but sooner or later the problems reoccurred.”

Lithuania: “Common errors have been discussed with VFS, but only temporary improvement noticed. After a while some errors occurred.”

Poland: “Problems discussed many times, but they still occur.”

Slots sold, services pushed

Member states were also asked whether there had been allegations of irregularities or corruption at VFS. Most said their embassies had received complaints but that no hard evidence had been produced. The responses on specifics, however, were pointed.

Lithuania stated: “There were some anonymous letters and complaints received from applicants that online appointment slots are being sold by VFS. The problem has been discussed with VFS, they have initiated investigations, some staff members have been replaced, but situation has not changed drastically.”

Poland said: “We receive these kind of allegations almost daily, mostly concerning selling slots. We discuss with VFS, but usually there is no hard proof that there is staff involved. Sometimes there are allegations concerning individuals who pretend to be VFS staff.”

Sweden’s response: “Embassy has received complaints from applicants who have expressed dissatisfaction with the VFS for allegedly forcing them to avail extra paid services. They claim that VFS staff did not provide them with the choice to decline. Embassy discussed with VFS and VFS has been instructed to introduce a consent form for the extra service they offered, which will require the applicant’s consent and signature.”

And yet, some member states said they needed to work with VFS Global. Switzerland said, “We have no other option to see VFS as a partner and to work intensively with them because we ourselves will never be able to accept this number of applications... there is certainly lack of a competing company in India.”

The big picture: Covid and after

Beyond the inspection findings, leaked EU documents accessed as part of this investigation shed further light on the systemic pressures around Schengen visa processing in India. A 2023 report of the Local Schengen Cooperation group, which held seven meetings that year, captures the post-Covid strain on the system.

On the surge in applications after Covid-19 travel restrictions were lifted, the report notes: “The huge influx of requests, choking the visa processing capabilities of most member states, continued to be compounded by a noticeable increase of first-time visa requests substantiated with fake or forced documents, increasing the average processing time. Visa shopping also remained a phenomenon.”

● POLICY

VB-G RAM G rules: What changes as scheme set to replace NREGS

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, May 27

THE VIKSIT Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025, is set to come into force from July 1, replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA). Ahead of the nationwide roll-out of the new rural jobs scheme, the Union government has released a draft of the rules that will govern its implementation.

The VB-G RAM G Act increases the number of guaranteed wage employment days, shifts a significant portion of the funding burden onto states, and turns resource allocation into a top-down process. The rules create a new provision (not mentioned directly in the Act) allowing those with verified MGNREGS job cards to avail work under the new scheme. They call for using the Sixteenth Finance Commission's formula to determine the Centre's normative allocation for states. And another new provision also allows the Union government to keep aside a portion of the normative allocation based on certain parameters. Here's a look at the new rules and their implications.

What are the new rules?

The Ministry of Rural Development on May 23 released eight draft rules that cover the VB-G RAM G scheme's provisions regarding wage payment, unemployment allowances, allocations to states and implementation monitoring. These are the rules:

- National Level Steering Committee Rules
- Grievance Redressal Rules
- Administrative Expenses Rules
- Transitional Provisions under VB-G RAM G Rules
- Objective Parameters for Normative Allocation Rules
- Central Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Council Rules
- Manner of Payment of Wages and Unemployment Allowance Rules
- Manner and Procedure of Expenditure incurred by the State in excess of the Normative Allocation, and Expenses of the Scheme for UTs without Legislature Rules

The ministry has sought objections and suggestions from the public within a month, after which it will notify the rules.

How do these affect NREGS workers?

Among the new rules, the Transitional Provisions are the most significant for exist-

VB-G RAM G vs MGNREGS

- VB-G RAM G increases the number of working days from 100 to 125 and provides for a 60-day pause during sowing and harvesting seasons to ensure the availability of farm labour.
- In MGNREGS, the Centre paid 100% of the wage bill. VB-G RAM G shifts a significant portion of the funding burden onto states.
- VB-G RAM G flips the MGNREGS model of Central allocations based on state labour budgets, with Centre now determining devolutions.

ing MGNREGS workers. Their MGNREGS job cards, once renewed and verified through e-KYC, will remain valid for seeking employment under the VB-G RAM G Act. This arrangement will continue until state governments issue Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards under the new law. The rules also specify that all wage and unemployment allowance payments will be made through Direct Benefit Transfer into bank or post office accounts. The Union government, however, is yet to declare the wage rate under the VB-G RAM G scheme.

How do they affect the states?

The Union government has allocated Rs 95,692.31 crore for the VB-G RAM G scheme for this financial year (2026-27).

For states, the rules that are the most crucial are those related to fund allocation and excess expenditure.

According to the draft Objective Parameters for Normative Allocation Rules, 2026: "The Central Government shall, for each financial year, determine the normative allocation of the funds, for every State, based on the objective parameters specified in these rules."

According to the rules, the Centre will

use the Sixteenth Finance Commission's horizontal devolution recommendations to determine the normative allocation to states. Using the Sixteenth Finance Commission formula, some states may receive lower VB-G RAM G allocations than they did under MGNREGS in 2025-26. These include Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Maharashtra. On the other hand, the shares of Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Assam, Haryana, Punjab and Bihar will likely increase.

Crucially, the draft rules have a provision regarding keeping aside a portion of the normative allocation, which will be distributed among states based on certain parameters — timely payment of wages; compliance with social audit requirements; the percentage of completion of work in a financial year; and other performance-related indicators as may be specified by the Centre. The proportion of the normative allocation that can be kept aside has not been decided yet. This provision will take effect from the next financial year.

Another significant rule, as already set out in the Act, says that states will have to bear any additional expenditure over the normative allocation.

AMERICAN TRADE TEAM HEADS TO INDIA NEXT WEEK

USTR Greer to meet Goyal ‘soon’, finalise India-US deal framework

Govt officials said India expects a comparative advantage in the new US tariffs for the deal to be finalised

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, May 27

UNITED STATES Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer on Wednesday said he expects to meet Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal soon to finalise the India-US deal framework under discussion since early this year.

New Delhi and Washington had agreed to the framework for a deal, but the reciprocal tariffs that served as the basis of the American trade agreements were declared illegal by the US Supreme Court in February.

“On New Delhi, we have had many meaningful discussions. We have a framework agreement with the Indians. I have a team going there next week. I expect to meet my counterpart (Piyush Goyal) soon as well. I’d really like to be in a position to finalise our agreement based on the joint framework agreement we agreed to,” Greer said at a Council of Foreign Relations conference.

Greer’s comments come as

the US is expected to come out with a new tariff architecture next month to replace reciprocal tariffs.

The new set of tariffs is expected to follow the Section 301 investigation that the US launched in March on scores of countries, including India. Government officials said India expects a comparative advantage in the new US tariffs for the deal to be finalised.

“As we wrap up some of the Section 301 investigation in the coming months, USTR will put out a federal register notice to communicate our findings if we find something objectionable, then we can make a proposal — whether it’s tariffs, quotas or export control measures and investment creating measures,” Greer said.

Later in the day, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry also said the US team, led by the Chief Negotiator, will be visiting India from June 1-4, 2026.

“It is proposed to finalise the details of the Interim Agreement and take forward

NEW TARIFF ARCHITECTURE UNDERWAY

GREER’S COMMENTS come as the US is expected to come out with a new tariff architecture next month to replace reciprocal tariffs

THE NEW set of tariffs is expected to follow the Section 301 investigation that the US launched in March on scores of countries, including India

TALKS WITH the US for a deal assume significance as several countries are holding on to capex investment, awaiting



Washington’s new tariff architecture

the negotiations under the broader BTA on multiple areas such as market access, non-tariff measures, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, economic security alignment,” the ministry said.

Ahead of the US-India trade talks next week, an Indian trade delegation is in Canada for negotiations to sign a deal with Ottawa by the end of the year.

Talks with Ottawa have picked up amid ongoing US-Mexico-Canada Agreement negotiations, where the US and Mexico have started talks without Canada following a trade

war. Amid testy US-Canada ties, Goyal has led a delegation with 100 industry leaders.

The Ministry of Commerce said that Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement negotiations have moved swiftly since the Terms of Reference were signed in March 2025.

“A first round of virtual talks was held in March 2026, followed by a second round that concluded on May 8, 2026. A concurrent round of technical negotiations is underway in Ottawa from May 25-29, running in parallel with Minister Goyal’s visit, signalling the

seriousness and pace both sides are bringing to the process,” the ministry said. Talks with the US for a deal assume significance as several countries are holding on to capex investment, awaiting Washington’s new tariff architecture.

For India, a slowdown in investments has resulted in a rapidly weakening currency.

The country saw gross foreign direct investment inflows rise to a new record high of \$94.53 billion in 2025-26, up 17% from the previous year, although the net figure was a mere \$7.65 billion, data released last week by the Reserve Bank of India showed.

Inflows had risen sharply in February on the back of global investor sentiment reversing in the wake of the signing of an interim trade deal between India and the US earlier that month, which eliminated the penal 25% tariff and reduced the reciprocal tariff to 18% from 25%.

Foreign portfolio investors had also net bought Indian financial assets in February to the tune of \$4.17 billion.

However, once the West Asia war began at the end of February, foreign capital has exited India in droves: \$13.6 billion in March, \$7.56 billion in April, and \$2.62 billion in May so far.

Hong Kong overtakes Switzerland as world’s top cross-border wealth hub on China ties: BCG

Reuters
Zurich, May 27

HONG KONG has overtaken Switzerland as the top global booking centre for cross-border wealth, a first that is unlikely to be reversed as hubs in Asia grow faster than the European safe-haven, Boston Consulting Group (BCG) said Wednesday.

Wealth from China and an IPO boom in 2025 helped Hong Kong rise to a \$2.95 trillion offshore behemoth for the world’s rich, narrowly surpassing Switzerland’s \$2.94 trillion in cross-

border wealth, as per BCG’s 2026 Global Wealth Report.

“Hong Kong is cementing its role as China’s gateway to global markets, though that same concentration ties its trajectory tightly to economic and regulatory developments on the mainland,” the authors said.

Both Hong Kong and Singapore are projected to continue growing as cross-border booking centres at around 9% annually through 2030, compared to an expected 6% average in Switzerland over the same period.

Cross-border wealth glo-

bally grew 8.4% to \$15.7 trillion last year, driven by strong markets and demand for geographical diversification, and it flowed overwhelmingly to the world’s top 10 booking centres, further boosting concentration, it added.

Despite slower growth rates, Switzerland’s diversification may prove an advantage as it draws clients from all regions, while Asian hubs largely depend on growth in China, BCG added.

“Geopolitical uncertainty reaffirms Switzerland’s role as a core global booking centre, at-

tracting flight-to-safety flows from more volatile regions such as the Middle East,” BCG said. Wealthy individuals have been looking to shift assets from the Gulf region to Switzerland in the wake of the ongoing conflict, bankers and financial advisers have told Reuters.

“What ultimately matters is client proximity,” said Michael Kahllich, the report’s co-author, adding that two hubs are forming globally — Singapore and Hong Kong for Asia, and Switzerland, the UK, and the US for the West.

'Breakneck' Ebola epidemic in Congo outpaces global response

Reuters

Geneva, May 27

IN AN Ebola outbreak, hours matter. Yet the response to the deadly and fast-spreading epidemic in the Democratic Republic of Congo is weeks if not months behind - and missing thousands of people who may be at risk.

Interviews with global health officials and documents from a meeting led by the World Health Organiza-

tion and Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention show how behind the curve authorities are in fighting the latest outbreak.

Caused by a strain of the virus known as Bundibugyo for which there is no vaccine or treatment, the outbreak has already caused a suspected 220 deaths and 900 cases, according to the WHO.

It has spread to Uganda, where there are seven cases. Health teams are racing

to find thousands of people who may have been exposed to the virus while also grappling with myriad challenges that make it difficult to contain.

Problems at a local level include lack of basic supplies as well as mistrust from a community scarred by previous outbreaks.

Globally, the response is hampered by the withdrawal of the US from the WHO and wider funding cuts, many health sources said. Documents from

Friday's virtual coordination meeting show that, as of last week, only 7% of the 1,261 people identified as contacts of suspected Ebola patients had been found and followed up. The WHO put the number at more than 2,000 on Wednesday.

The outbreak is “outpacing the response”, WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus posted on Wednesday. “Attacks on health facilities make tracking cases and their contacts nearly impossible.”

In eastern Congo, the worst-hit area, hospitals have been attacked and isolation tents burned by angry mobs reclaiming bodies of loved ones, apparently unaware of risks from infectious corpses.

That is hindering the operation to stop the spread of the virus and track those at risk in an area already wracked with conflict and with poor health infrastructure, three experts said. In a document summary of the meeting on Friday, the

partners agreed that reaching more contacts is now the key priority as funding and emergency response personnel trickle in. "Bottom line: No vaccine exists. No therapy exists.

The virus circulated undetected for six weeks. Cross-border spread is confirmed. Healthcare workers are dying. Every day without a fully resourced response is a day the outbreak gains ground," a presentation by the WHO Africa team from the meeting reads.